From Rule Selection to Constraint Following: Evaluating Open-Weight LLMs on Macedonian and English Instructions

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Abstract

Instruction following requires a model to satisfy several explicit constraints at the same time, not only to produce a fluent answer. In our previous work, RuleTreeBench, we found that models which were correct at abstract rule selection struggled on a richer, real-world rule-based task. In this work, we move from controlled rule selection to natural-language instructions with cumulative constraints, and we study this ability in English and in Macedonian, a low-resource language. We use a paired English–Macedonian subset of FollowBench with four constraint categories (Content, Situation, Style, Format), five instruction families per category, and five levels, where each level adds one constraint. Four open-weight models, Qwen3.5 9B, Gemma 4 12B, Llama 3.1 8B, and the Macedonian-adapted Domestic-Yak 8B, produced 800 responses. The responses were evaluated by two LLM judges, GPT-5.6 Sol and Claude Opus 5.5, which agreed on the overall verdict (whether a response satisfied all of its constraints) for 89.4% of the 705 judged responses; all disagreements were resolved by human judgement. The three general-purpose models satisfied all constraints less often in Macedonian than in English, with the largest difference for Llama 3.1 8B. Domestic-Yak 8B satisfied all constraints in fewer than 10% of prompts in both languages. The difference was small at the first level, became larger once several constraints had to be satisfied together, and was largest for Style constraints. Gemma 4 12B, which was correct on all RuleTreeBench prompts, satisfied all constraints in 60% of English and 50% of Macedonian prompts. Strong controlled rule selection therefore did not imply reliable multi-constraint instruction following, especially in Macedonian.

Keywords: instruction following, multi-constraint evaluation, large language models, open-weight language models, Macedonian, low-resource languages, cross-lingual evaluation, LLM-as-a-judge, FollowBench

1 Introduction

Large language models (LLMs) are often asked to do more than answer a question. A user may ask for an answer in a table, in a certain tone, under a word limit, and for a specific audience, all at the same time. A response is useful only if it satisfies all of these constraints together. A fluent answer that ignores one of them is still a failure from the user's point of view.

In our previous work, RuleTreeBench [1], we studied rule reasoning in a controlled, context-neutral setting. The model received a query and a list of abstract rules and had to select the rule that applied. We evaluated Qwen3 4B, Qwen3 8B, Gemma 3 4B, and Gemma 4 12B. Three of them were correct on at least 96% of the prompts, and Gemma 4 12B was correct on all 1,700 prompts. However, the same models performed poorly on RuleArena [2], an end-to-end task with real rules written in natural language. Strong performance on controlled

rule selection did not transfer to the richer task. This result raises a natural next question: what happens when the rules are ordinary natural-language instructions that accumulate and must all be satisfied at once?

FollowBench [3] provides a suitable setting for this question. Each instruction family starts from a base task, and each of five levels adds one more constraint. At level n, a response must therefore satisfy n constraints together. The benchmark measures whether all constraints are satisfied, how many are satisfied, and how many consecutive levels a model can complete. Compared with RuleTreeBench, the task is less controlled: the constraints are written in natural language, the answers are open-ended, and correctness cannot be computed from a formula.

A second question is whether this ability depends on the language of the instruction. Most instruction-following benchmarks are in English, while Macedonian is a low-resource language with limited model and evaluation resources [4]. Recent work has introduced Macedonian-adapted models, such as Domestic-Yak, and evaluated them on knowledge, reasoning, and answer quality [4]. It is less clear whether open-weight models follow explicit, layered constraints equally well when the same instruction is given in Macedonian.

To study these questions, we build FollowBench-MK, a paired English–Macedonian subset of FollowBench. It contains 20 instruction families from four constraint categories (Content, Situation, Style, and Format), each with five levels, in both languages. We evaluate four open-weight models, Qwen3.5 9B, Gemma 4 12B, Llama 3.1 8B, and the Macedonian-adapted Domestic-Yak 8B, which gives 800 responses. Because the answers are open-ended, each response is evaluated constraint by constraint by two independent LLM judges, and all disagreements are resolved by human adjudication.

The paper answers four research questions:

- **RQ1 — Language.** Do models satisfy instruction constraints less often in Macedonian than in English when given the same prompts?
- **RQ2 — Models.** How do the four models compare in each language?
- **RQ3 — Constraint accumulation.** How does performance change as constraints accumulate from level 1 to level 5, and does the language difference depend on the level?
- **RQ4 — Constraint category.** Which constraint categories are hardest, and which differ most between the two languages?

Table 1 summarizes how each research question is linked to the corresponding analysis and main evidence.

Table 1: Research questions and the analyses used to answer them.

RQ	Analysis	Main evidence
RQ1	Paired English–Macedonian comparison	HSR, SSR, and CSL per language; paired outcomes
RQ2	Model comparison	Results per model and language; truncation
RQ3	Results by level	HSR and SSR at L1–L5; CSL; failure consistency
RQ4	Results by category	HSR per category and language

The main contributions of this work are:

- a paired English–Macedonian subset of FollowBench with 800 model responses from four open-weight models;

- a two-judge evaluation procedure that uses two LLM judges in isolated chat sessions and human adjudication of their disagreements;
- a comparison of the models across languages, difficulty levels, and constraint categories, which extends our previous rule-reasoning work to natural-language, multi-constraint instructions.

Three findings stand out. First, the three general-purpose models satisfied all constraints less often in Macedonian than in English; the difference was largest for Llama 3.1 8B (43% vs. 22%) and smaller for Gemma 4 12B (60% vs. 50%) and Qwen3.5 9B (59% vs. 51%). Second, the language difference was small when only one constraint was present and became larger once several constraints had to be satisfied together, with the largest difference for Style constraints. Third, Gemma 4 12B, which made no errors on RuleTreeBench, satisfied all constraints in 60% of English and 50% of Macedonian prompts, which shows that controlled rule selection does not by itself predict multi-constraint instruction following. The Macedonian-adapted Domestic-Yak 8B had low scores in both languages in our setting, so its English–Macedonian difference was close to zero (Section 6.4).

2 Related Work

2.1 Instruction-Following Benchmarks

Several benchmarks measure whether a model satisfies the explicit requirements of an instruction. IFEval [5] uses verifiable instructions, such as word counts or required keywords, which can be checked automatically. This makes scoring objective, but limits the benchmark to constraints with a programmatic check. InFoBench [6] decomposes each instruction into simple yes/no requirements and reports the Decomposed Requirements Following Ratio, the share of requirements a response satisfies. ComplexBench [7] studies how constraints are composed, for example in chains or selections, and combines LLM-based and rule-based evaluation.

FollowBench [3] is the benchmark we build on. It covers five fine-grained constraint types (Content, Situation, Style, Format, and Example) and a Mixed category. Each instruction family has five levels, and every level adds one constraint to the previous one, so a model is tested on the same task under a growing number of requirements. The benchmark reports the Hard Satisfaction Rate (HSR), the Soft Satisfaction Rate (SSR), and Consistent Satisfaction Levels (CSL). Responses are scored either by rules or by an LLM judge that receives the evolution path of the instruction. In the original evaluation, performance declined as constraints were added, and open models trailed the strongest closed model. FollowBench also includes a Chinese version, but, to our knowledge, it has not been studied in a low-resource language. We keep its multi-level design and metrics, and add a paired comparison between English and Macedonian.

2.2 Multilingual Instruction Following

Large-scale multilingual evaluations have shown that model quality drops for languages with less training data [8], and most of the world's languages remain poorly represented in NLP resources [9]. For instruction following specifically, M-IFEval [10] extends IFEval to French, Japanese, and Spanish, with language-specific instructions, and reports large differences across languages and instruction types. Multi-IF [11] combines multi-turn and multilingual instructions in eight languages, and finds higher error rates for languages written in non-Latin scripts (Hindi, Russian, and Chinese). These studies cover high- and medium-resource languages. Macedonian, a South Slavic language written in Cyrillic with far fewer resources, is not included. Our study adds this language, and uses aligned English–Macedonian prompt pairs so that the same model can be compared on the same instruction in both languages.

2.3 Rule Reasoning in Language Models

A related line of work asks whether models can apply explicit rules. RuLES [12] tests whether models keep to simple rules given in the prompt, such as a rule not to reveal a secret, and finds that this often fails under adversarial user input. RuleArena [2] evaluates rule-guided reasoning in realistic settings, such as airline baggage fees, NBA transactions, and tax regulations. In these settings, a model has to find the applicable rules in long, natural-language policies and compute an answer. Strong models made frequent errors in both rule selection and computation.

Our previous work, RuleTreeBench [1], studied rule selection in a controlled, context-neutral setting. Models received abstract rules and attributes, without real-world context, and had to select the applicable rule. On 1,700 prompts, Gemma 4 12B reached 100% accuracy, Qwen3 8B 98.4%, Qwen3 4B 96.5%, and Gemma 3 4B 68.4%. On the RuleArena airline task, used as an external check, the same models reached between 0% and 4.67%. High accuracy on controlled rule selection therefore did not transfer to a richer task. The present study follows from this result. Instead of a single rule, the model has to satisfy several natural-language constraints at the same time, and we test how this ability changes as constraints accumulate and when the instruction is given in Macedonian.

2.4 Language Models for Macedonian

Work on Macedonian language models has been limited by the lack of large, open resources. Krsteski et al. [4] addressed this gap with an open Macedonian corpus of about 40 GB of text (around 3.5 billion words) and an instruction dataset of 106k culturally grounded examples. They also released an evaluation suite of seven Macedonian benchmarks, and an 8B-parameter model, Domestic-Yak, obtained by continued pre-training of Llama 3.1 8B Instruct. On these benchmarks, Domestic-Yak outperformed models of similar size and performed comparably to much larger models, and native speakers preferred its answers for grammatical correctness and cultural appropriateness. Their evaluation focuses on knowledge, reasoning, and answer quality in Macedonian. It does not measure whether a model follows several explicit constraints in one instruction. Our study adds this dimension, and includes Domestic-Yak and the Llama 3.1 8B model it was adapted from among the evaluated models.

2.5 LLMs as Judges

Using strong LLMs to evaluate model outputs has become common, because human evaluation is slow and costly. Zheng et al. [13] found that GPT-4 judgments agreed with human preferences at a level similar to agreement between humans. They also reported position, verbosity, and self-enhancement biases. Later work showed that the order of the candidates can change a judge's verdict [14], and that LLM evaluators can recognise and prefer their own outputs [15]. For multilingual evaluation, Hada et al. [16] found that LLM-based evaluators tend to give higher scores than human judges, especially in low-resource and non-Latin-script languages, and recommended calibration against native-speaker judgments. FollowBench validated its GPT-4 judge against human annotations and found 88% agreement, compared with 79% when the judge did not receive the evolution path [3].

These findings motivate our judging procedure. Instead of one judge, we use two judges from different model families, which receive the same blinded and shuffled batches in isolated sessions. None of the four evaluated models comes from these families, which limits self-preference. We report the agreement between the two judges, and every disagreement is resolved by the authors through human adjudication.

3 Benchmark and Dataset

3.1 FollowBench

FollowBench [3] contains 820 instructions, organised into six constraint categories: Content, Situation, Style, Format, Example, and Mixed. The instructions are grouped into instruction families. Each family starts from one base task and has five levels (L1–L5). Every level repeats the task of the previous level and adds one new constraint, so a level-n instruction contains n constraints that must all be satisfied at the same time. We use the English instructions from the official FollowBench GitHub release. Table 2 shows one family from our subset.

The six categories differ in what the constraints control [3]:

- **Content**: explicit conditions on the depth or scope of the answer, for example what it must include.
- **Situation**: a specific situation or background that implicitly guides the appropriate answer, such as a role or a scenario.
- **Style**: the style of the output, such as tone, sentiment, formality, or a persona.
- **Format**: the structure and presentation of the output, such as a table, a list, or a length limit.
- **Example**: following a pattern shown in a set of examples.
- **Mixed**: a combination of constraints from several categories.

Table 2: Example instruction family (content_002). The L1 instruction is shown in full; for L2–L5, only the constraint added at that level is shown. Each level keeps all earlier constraints.

Level	Instruction / added constraint
L1	*What is the sole responsibility of business according to Milton Friedman, while also considering its implications on societal ethics?*
L2	Name one potential consequence on community relations.
L3	Include one relevant case study for context.
L4	Explain the implications of the case study.
L5	Cite one expert opinion or statistical data to support the viewpoint.

3.2 Study Design

From the six FollowBench categories, we use four: Content, Situation, Style, and Format. In these categories, each family contains constraints of a single type and the answers are open-ended. We do not use Example, which tests pattern following and is scored by accuracy in FollowBench, or Mixed, which combines several constraint types, so that a difference there could not be linked to one type of constraint. For each category, we randomly selected five instruction families with a fixed random seed (42). With five levels per family, this gives 100 prompts per language. Each prompt was given to four models in English and in Macedonian, which gives 800 responses in total (Table 3). Every English prompt has a Macedonian counterpart with the same family and level, so each model can be compared with itself on the same instruction in both languages.

3.3 Macedonian Version

We chose Macedonian because it is a low-resource language with few instruction-following resources (Section 1). The Macedonian prompts were produced by machine translation of the

Table 3: Composition of FollowBench-MK.

Category	Families	Prompts per language	Responses
Content	content_002, 003, 006, 009, 019	25	200
Situation	situation_007, 008, 010, 012, 018	25	200
Style	style_001, 005, 022, 023, 028	25	200
Format	format_007, 016, 018, 020, 027	25	200
Total	20 families × 5 levels	100	800

original English FollowBench prompts with GPT-5.6 Sol. The English prompts were sent in batches, and each batch was translated in a new chat. Every level of every family was translated as a complete instruction. The aim was to keep the original meaning, the constraints, the five difficulty levels, and the structure of each prompt, so that every Macedonian prompt is a direct counterpart of its English prompt. Both authors are native Macedonian speakers and fluent in English. We read a sample of the translated prompts and found them adequate, so no corrections were made.

3.4 Evaluation Criteria

As in FollowBench [3], the judges answer YES or NO for each constraint separately. FollowBench's judge has to work out the constraints on its own. We instead give the judges a short list of checks, called criteria, where each criterion is one thing the response must do. A level-1 prompt has one criterion, a level-2 prompt has two, and so on up to five. Every list is written in both English and Macedonian, so each response is checked in its own language.

In four families (content_019, situation_007, situation_008, and style_001), each level changes the task instead of adding a new rule. In a math problem, for example, the correct answer is different at every level. For these families, each level has just one criterion: the correct answer.

4 Experimental Setup

4.1 Models

We evaluate four open-weight models (Table 4). Three of them are general-purpose models that their developers describe as multilingual: Qwen3.5 9B supports 201 languages and dialects [17], Gemma 4 12B was pre-trained on over 140 languages [18], and Llama 3.1 8B officially supports eight languages, which do not include Macedonian [19]. Llama 3.1 8B and a Qwen model were also baselines in the Domestic-Yak paper [4]. The fourth model, Domestic-Yak 8B, is Llama 3.1 8B further trained on Macedonian data [4]. Gemma 4 12B and the Qwen family also connect this study to RuleTreeBench, which evaluated Gemma 4 12B and Qwen3 models.

Table 4: Models used in the evaluation.

Model	Hugging Face identifier	Type
Qwen3.5 9B	`Qwen/Qwen3.5-9B`	General-purpose
Gemma 4 12B	`google/gemma-4-12B-it`	General-purpose
Llama 3.1 8B	`meta-llama/Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct`	General-purpose
Domestic-Yak 8B	`LVSTCK/domestic-yak-8B-instruct`	Macedonian-adapted

4.2 Inference

All models were run with the same settings on a Tesla T4 GPU (16 GB) in Google Colab, using the Hugging Face `transformers` library. The models were loaded in 4-bit NF4 quantization so that they fit on the GPU. We used greedy decoding, a fixed seed (42), and a limit of 2,048 new tokens. Each prompt was sent as a single user message in the model's own chat template, without a system prompt. For Qwen3.5 9B and Gemma 4 12B, the thinking mode was turned off, and none of the responses contained reasoning text. A response that reached the 2,048-token limit was marked as *truncated*. Further details are given in Appendix C.

4.3 Judging Procedure

Each response was evaluated by two LLM judges: GPT-5.6 Sol in ChatGPT (Judge A) and Claude Opus 5.5 in Claude (Judge B), both with thinking turned on. The judges were used through their chat applications, in a temporary chat (ChatGPT) and an incognito chat (Claude). We opened a new chat for every batch, and turned off memory, personalisation, web search, and connectors, so that the judges could not use earlier conversations or outside sources (Appendix B).

Truncated responses were not judged (Section 4.5). The remaining 705 responses were given opaque identifiers, so that the judges did not see which model produced them. The responses were shuffled across models and languages and split into 29 batches of 24 or 25 items. Both judges received the same batches and the same fixed instructions (Appendix A). For each item, the judge saw the instruction, the response, and the criteria of that level, and returned YES, NO, or UNCERTAIN for every criterion, with a short piece of evidence. Unlike FollowBench, the judges did not see the earlier levels of the instruction; instead, all constraints of the current level were listed as separate criteria. For example, the L3 prompt of content_002 was judged with three criteria, C1–C3, one for each constraint in Table 2. All families, including those with one criterion per level, were judged in the same way.

4.4 Human Adjudication

If both judges gave the same decision for every criterion of a response, their decisions were final. Otherwise, the response was sent to human adjudication. This applied to 150 responses. The two authors, both native Macedonian speakers, read the instruction, the response, and the decisions and evidence of both judges, discussed each case, and agreed on the final decision for every criterion where the judges differed. The judges never returned UNCERTAIN.

4.5 Metrics

We use the three FollowBench metrics [3]. For a response with n criteria, let $s_j = 1$ if criterion j is satisfied and $s_j = 0$ otherwise.

- **Hard Satisfaction Rate (HSR)**: the share of responses that satisfy *all* of their criteria, $\prod_j s_j = 1$.
- **Soft Satisfaction Rate (SSR)**: the average share of satisfied criteria, $\frac{1}{n}\sum_j s_j$.
- **Consistent Satisfaction Levels (CSL)**: for each family, the number of consecutive levels, starting from L1, in which all criteria are satisfied (0–5), averaged over families.

As in FollowBench, HSR and SSR are first computed for each category and level, and then averaged; CSL is averaged over the families of each category and then over categories.

Truncated responses are handled in two ways. In **Analysis A**, our main analysis, a truncated response counts as a failure: none of its criteria are satisfied, and it ends the CSL chain of its

family. In **Analysis B**, used as a check, truncated responses are left out (Section 5.7 and Appendix D). For HSR, we report Wilson 95% confidence intervals over the 100 responses of each model and language. Results by level ($n = 20$ per model and language) and by category ($n = 25$) are descriptive.

5 Results

5.1 Truncated Responses

Out of 800 responses, 95 (11.9%) reached the token limit: 27 of 400 in English (6.8%) and 68 of 400 in Macedonian (17.0%). Truncation was more frequent in Macedonian for every model (Figure 1). It was rare for Qwen3.5 9B (1 in English, 6 in Macedonian) and Gemma 4 12B (4 and 10), more frequent for Llama 3.1 8B (0 and 16), and most frequent for Domestic-Yak 8B (22 and 36). Most truncated responses (90 of 95) were repetition loops; the remaining 5 were long answers that reached the token limit. This leaves 705 judged responses, 373 in English and 332 in Macedonian.

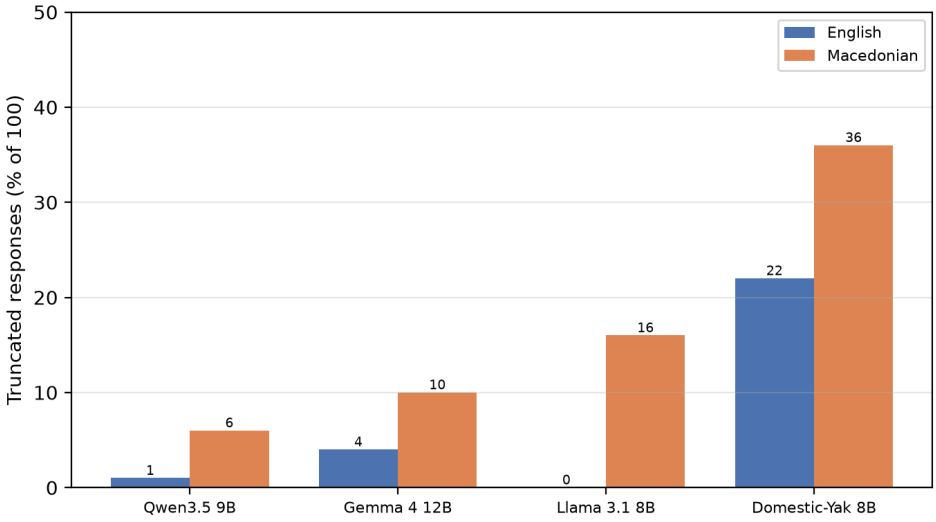


Figure 1: Truncated responses per model and language (out of 100 each).

5.2 Judge Agreement

For each response, we call a judge's verdict *satisfied* if it marked every criterion as satisfied, and *not satisfied* otherwise; this is the same decision that HSR uses. The two judges reached the same verdict for 630 of the 705 judged responses (89.4%), with similar agreement in English and Macedonian (Table 5). The 150 responses sent to adjudication include these 75 cases with different verdicts, and 75 cases with the same verdict but a different decision on at least one criterion. ChatGPT Sol 5.6 was slightly more lenient than Claude Opus 5.5: HSR computed with ChatGPT's decisions alone was higher than with Claude's decisions alone in seven of the eight model–language pairs and equal in one (Section 5.7).

5.3 RQ1: English vs. Macedonian

Table 6 shows the main results. The three general-purpose models scored lower in Macedonian on all three metrics. The HSR difference was 8.0 percentage points for Qwen3.5 9B (59.0% vs. 51.0%), 10.0 points for Gemma 4 12B (60.0% vs. 50.0%), and 21.0 points for Llama 3.1 8B (43.0% vs. 22.0%). For Llama 3.1 8B, the Wilson intervals of the two languages do not overlap,

Table 5: Agreement between the two judges on whether a response satisfied all of its criteria.

Group	Judged responses	Same verdict	Agreement
English	373	333	89.3%
Macedonian	332	297	89.5%
All	705	630	89.4%

so the difference is larger than what sampling variation alone would explain. For Qwen3.5 9B and Gemma 4 12B, the intervals overlap, so with 100 prompts per language these two differences are less certain. SSR showed the same pattern, with differences of about 10, 10, and 22 points. Domestic-Yak 8B had very low scores in both languages (7.0% and 8.0% HSR), so its language difference is close to zero.

Table 6: Main results per model and language (Analysis A, 100 prompts each). Brackets show Wilson 95% confidence intervals for HSR.

Model	Lang.	Judged	HSR (%)	SSR (%)	CSL
Qwen3.5 9B	EN	99	59.0 [49.2, 68.1]	77.0	2.70
	MK	94	51.0 [41.3, 60.6]	67.2	2.20
Gemma 4 12B	EN	96	60.0 [50.2, 69.1]	74.9	2.60
	MK	90	50.0 [40.4, 59.6]	64.6	2.05
Llama 3.1 8B	EN	100	43.0 [33.7, 52.8]	62.5	1.75
	MK	84	22.0 [15.0, 31.1]	40.2	0.95
Domestic-Yak 8B	EN	78	7.0 [3.4, 13.7]	21.6	0.20
	MK	64	8.0 [4.1, 15.0]	17.8	0.30

Because every English prompt has a Macedonian counterpart, we can also compare the two languages prompt by prompt (Table 7). For each model, we count the prompts where all constraints were satisfied only in English, and those where they were satisfied only in Macedonian. Over all four models, this gives 400 prompt pairs: 60 were satisfied only in English and 22 only in Macedonian. Most pairs had the same outcome in both languages. For Llama 3.1 8B, 22 prompts were satisfied only in English and 1 only in Macedonian. For Domestic-Yak 8B, the two counts were similar (6 and 7), and 86 of its 100 prompt pairs were not satisfied in either language.

Table 7: Paired English–Macedonian outcomes per model (Analysis A). Each model has 100 prompt pairs; "satisfied" means that all constraints were satisfied.

Model	Both	Only EN	Only MK	Neither
Qwen3.5 9B	43	16	8	33
Gemma 4 12B	44	16	6	34
Llama 3.1 8B	21	22	1	56
Domestic-Yak 8B	1	6	7	86
Total	109	60	22	209

5.4 RQ2: Model Comparison

The models form the same three groups in both languages (Table 6, Figure 2). Qwen3.5 9B and Gemma 4 12B were the strongest and very close to each other: Gemma 4 12B was 1 point higher

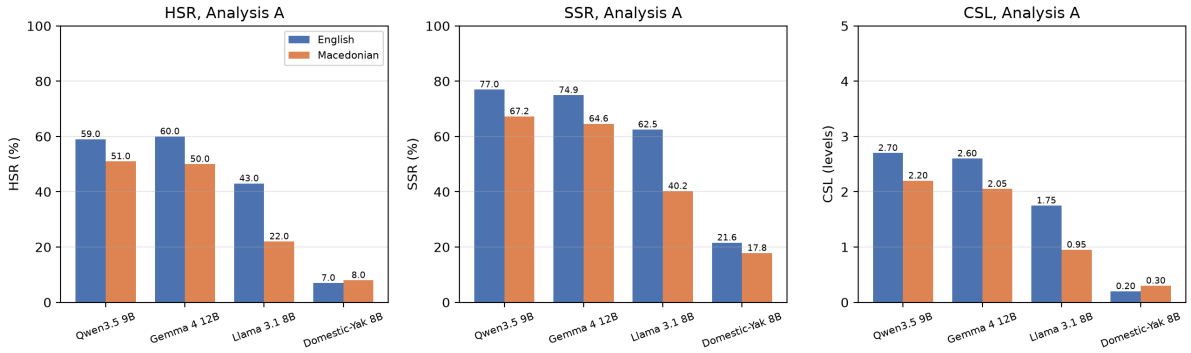


Figure 2: HSR, SSR, and CSL per model in English and Macedonian (Analysis A).

in English, and Qwen3.5 9B was 1 point higher in Macedonian. Llama 3.1 8B was clearly lower, especially in Macedonian, where its HSR was about half of its English HSR. Domestic-Yak 8B had the lowest scores in both languages. It also had the most truncated responses (22 in English and 36 in Macedonian). Part of its low score comes from responses that never finished, but even when they are left out (Analysis B), its HSR is only 9.0% in English and 12.5% in Macedonian.

The ranking also reflects the differences in truncation. Qwen3.5 9B and Gemma 4 12B rarely reached the token limit, while Llama 3.1 8B did so in 16 Macedonian responses and never in English. This explains part, but not all, of Llama's language difference: when truncated responses are left out (Analysis B), its HSR is still 43.0% in English and 26.2% in Macedonian (Section 5.7).

5.5 RQ3: Results by Level

HSR decreased as constraints were added, in both languages (Figure 3, Table 8). In English, HSR fell from L1 to L5 from 85% to 35% for Qwen3.5 9B, from 75% to 40% for Gemma 4 12B, and from 60% to 25% for Llama 3.1 8B. SSR decreased much less (for example, from 85.0% to 67.0% for Qwen3.5 9B and from 75.0% to 73.0% for Gemma 4 12B). This means that most constraints were still satisfied at higher levels, but it became less likely that *all* of them were satisfied together.

The language difference depended on the level. At L1, with a single constraint, each of the three general-purpose models was only 5 points lower in Macedonian. From L2 to L5, the average difference for these three models was 18.3, 11.7, 20.0, and 10.0 points. The largest change was for Llama 3.1 8B, whose Macedonian HSR fell from 55% at L1 to 25% at L2 and to 5–15% at L3–L5. Truncation in Macedonian also increased at higher levels: over all models, 11, 10, 12, 18, and 17 Macedonian responses were truncated from L1 to L5, compared with 3, 4, 6, 9, and 5 in English. CSL was lower in Macedonian for all three general-purpose models (2.20 vs. 2.70 for Qwen3.5 9B, 2.05 vs. 2.60 for Gemma 4 12B, and 0.95 vs. 1.75 for Llama 3.1 8B). Domestic-Yak 8B satisfied all constraints in 15–20% of prompts at L1 and in 0–5% from L3 onwards in both languages, with a CSL of 0.20 in English and 0.30 in Macedonian. SSR by level is shown in Appendix D (Figure 5).

Following FollowBench, we also measured *failure consistency*: when a model fails a level (HSR = 0), how often it also fails every later level of the same family. The values were high for all models (Table 9): between 75.0% and 82.1% for Qwen3.5 9B and Gemma 4 12B, around 91% for Llama 3.1 8B, and above 93% for Domestic-Yak 8B. Once a model failed at some level, it rarely recovered at a later one. The values were not higher in Macedonian than in English for Qwen3.5 9B and Gemma 4 12B.

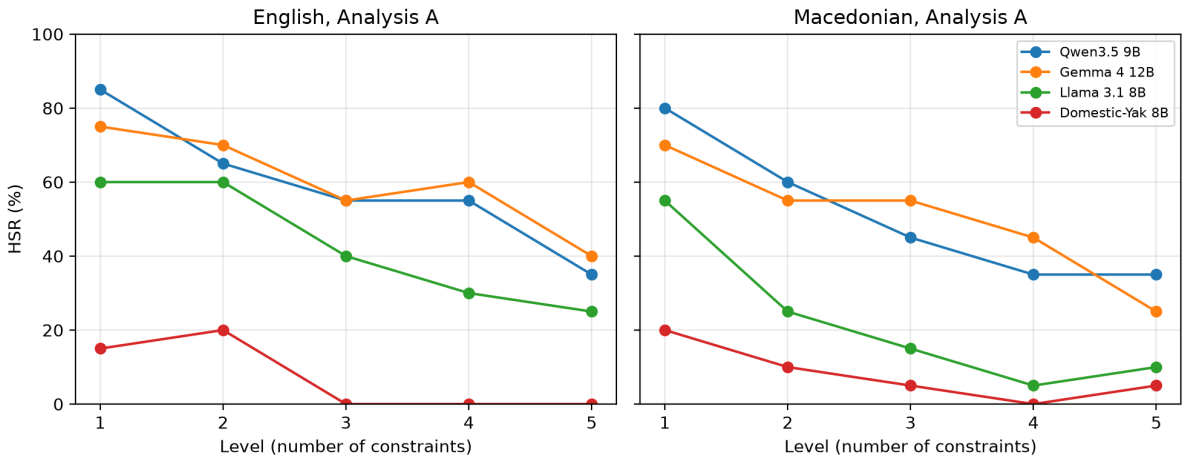


Figure 3: Hard satisfaction rate by level in English (left) and Macedonian (right), Analysis A.

Table 8: HSR (%) by level and CSL (Analysis A, $n = 20$ per level).

Model	Lang.	L1	L2	L3	L4	L5	Avg	CSL
Qwen3.5 9B	EN	85.0	65.0	55.0	55.0	35.0	59.0	2.70
	MK	80.0	60.0	45.0	35.0	35.0	51.0	2.20
Gemma 4 12B	EN	75.0	70.0	55.0	60.0	40.0	60.0	2.60
	MK	70.0	55.0	55.0	45.0	25.0	50.0	2.05
Llama 3.1 8B	EN	60.0	60.0	40.0	30.0	25.0	43.0	1.75
	MK	55.0	25.0	15.0	5.0	10.0	22.0	0.95
Domestic-Yak 8B	EN	15.0	20.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	7.0	0.20
	MK	20.0	10.0	5.0	0.0	5.0	8.0	0.30

5.6 RQ4: Results by Category

Figure 4 shows HSR per category. Each value is based on 25 prompts, so the results are descriptive. In English, the hardest category differed between models: Content was the lowest for Qwen3.5 9B (44%), Gemma 4 12B (36%), and Llama 3.1 8B (20%, together with Style). Format was the easiest for Gemma 4 12B (92%) and Llama 3.1 8B (72%), while Situation was the easiest for Qwen3.5 9B (72%).

Style showed the most consistent language difference. All three general-purpose models were at least 16 points lower in Macedonian: Qwen3.5 9B from 68% to 44%, Gemma 4 12B from 60% to 32%, and Llama 3.1 8B from 20% to 4%. The average difference for these three models was 22.7 points for Style, 16.0 for Format, 10.7 for Situation, and 2.7 for Content. The Format difference came mostly from Llama 3.1 8B (72% vs. 36%); Qwen3.5 9B had the same Format HSR in both languages. Style also had the most truncated Macedonian responses (28 of 100, compared with 11 of 100 in English), but the Style difference remained when truncated responses were left out (for example, 60.0% vs. 36.4% for Gemma 4 12B in Analysis B). Domestic-Yak 8B had an HSR of 16% or lower in every category and language; its highest value was for Format in Macedonian (16%).

5.7 Robustness Checks

We checked whether the main result depends on the judges or on the handling of truncated responses. Table 10 shows HSR computed with the final decisions, with the decisions of each judge alone, and with Analysis B. In every version, the three general-purpose models scored lower

Table 9: Failure consistency (Analysis A): share of failed levels L1–L4 after which every later level of the same family also failed. Counts in brackets.

Model	English	Macedonian
Qwen3.5 9B	78.6% (22/28)	75.0% (27/36)
Gemma 4 12B	82.1% (23/28)	77.1% (27/35)
Llama 3.1 8B	90.5% (38/42)	91.7% (55/60)
Domestic-Yak 8B	95.9% (70/73)	93.2% (68/73)

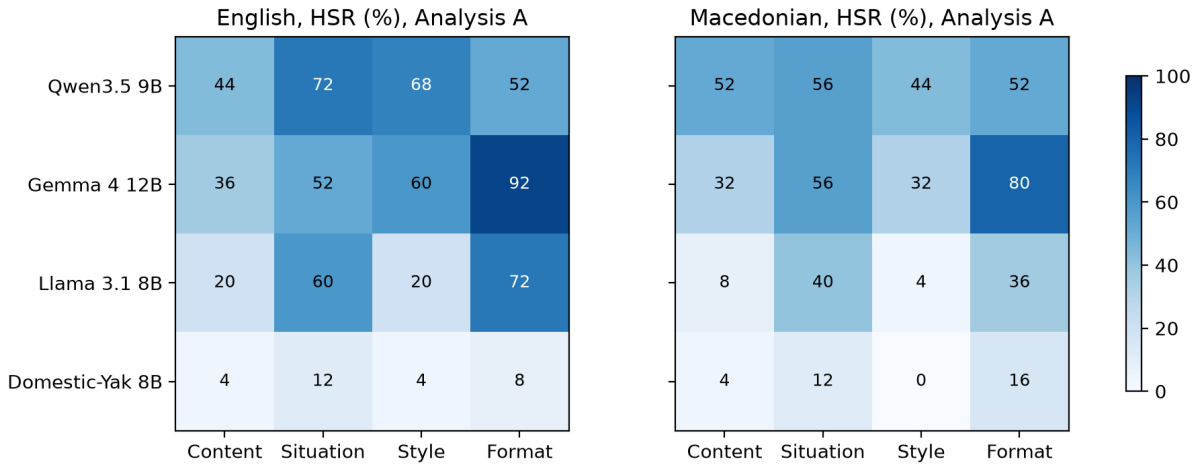


Figure 4: Hard satisfaction rate per model and constraint category (Analysis A, 25 prompts per cell).

in Macedonian than in English. Qwen3.5 9B and Gemma 4 12B stayed close to each other, Llama 3.1 8B stayed third, and Domestic-Yak 8B stayed last. In Analysis B, the language differences are smaller but remain: 5.3 points for Qwen3.5 9B, 6.9 for Gemma 4 12B, and 16.8 for Llama 3.1 8B. Domestic-Yak 8B stayed between 7.0% and 12.5% in all versions, and in Analysis B its Macedonian HSR was slightly higher than its English HSR (12.5% vs. 9.0%). The full Analysis B results, including SSR and CSL, are given in Table 12 and Figure 6 in Appendix D.

Table 10: HSR (%) in English / Macedonian under different decisions and truncation handling. The first three columns use Analysis A.

Model	Final	ChatGPT only	Claude only	Analysis B
Qwen3.5 9B	59.0 / 51.0	61.0 / 53.0	58.0 / 45.0	59.6 / 54.3
Gemma 4 12B	60.0 / 50.0	67.0 / 49.0	63.0 / 48.0	62.5 / 55.6
Llama 3.1 8B	43.0 / 22.0	46.0 / 24.0	41.0 / 23.0	43.0 / 26.2
Domestic-Yak 8B	7.0 / 8.0	8.0 / 10.0	8.0 / 9.0	9.0 / 12.5

5.8 Summary by Research Question

RQ1 — Language. The three general-purpose models satisfied all constraints less often in Macedonian, by 8 to 21 points in HSR. Of the 400 English–Macedonian prompt pairs, 60 were satisfied only in English and 22 only in Macedonian. The difference was clearest for Llama 3.1 8B.

RQ2 — Models. Qwen3.5 9B and Gemma 4 12B performed best and almost equally, Llama 3.1 8B was third, and Domestic-Yak 8B was last in both languages, with the most truncated responses.

RQ3 — Constraint accumulation. HSR decreased from L1 to L5 in both languages, while SSR decreased much less. The language difference was 5 points at L1 and larger from L2 onwards. Once a model failed a level, it usually failed all later levels.

RQ4 — Constraint category. The hardest category differed between models, but Style showed the largest and most consistent language difference.

6 Discussion

6.1 The Language Difference Appears with Accumulated Constraints

At L1, the general-purpose models performed almost equally in both languages. This suggests that they understood the Macedonian tasks and could satisfy a single constraint in Macedonian. The difference became larger when several constraints had to be satisfied together. One possible explanation is that keeping several requirements in mind while generating text is harder in a language with less training data. A second factor is truncation: repetition loops were more frequent in Macedonian, and they were more frequent at higher levels. However, the difference remained for all three general-purpose models, although smaller, when truncated responses were left out, so truncation alone does not explain it. Style constraints, such as a tone or a persona, showed the largest difference. These constraints depend on how the text is written, which may be harder to control in Macedonian than constraints on content or structure.

6.2 From Rule Selection to Constraint Following

In RuleTreeBench, Gemma 4 12B selected the correct rule in all 1,700 prompts. In this study, the same model satisfied all constraints in 60% of English and 50% of Macedonian prompts, and its HSR fell to 40% (English) and 25% (Macedonian) at L5. The two tasks are different. In RuleTreeBench, the model chooses one rule from an explicit list, and the answer is short. Here, the model has to keep several natural-language constraints while writing a long, open answer. Together with the RuleArena results in our previous work, this shows that strong performance on controlled rule selection does not mean that a model will reliably follow several rules in realistic generation, and that this gap is larger in a low-resource language.

6.3 Relation to FollowBench

Our results agree with the main FollowBench finding that performance decreases as constraints are added. As in FollowBench, HSR decreased much more than SSR, because a response fails HSR as soon as one constraint is missed. Failure consistency was higher in our study than the values reported by the FollowBench authors, for example 42.2% for GPT-4 and 64.0% for ChatGLM3-6B [3]. Our models are smaller, quantized, and evaluated on a smaller subset with different judges, so the values are not directly comparable. Still, they suggest that once these models fail at some level, they rarely recover at later levels.

6.4 General and Macedonian-Adapted Models

In our setting, Domestic-Yak 8B scored lower than Llama 3.1 8B, the model it was adapted from, in both languages, including Macedonian (8.0% vs. 22.0% HSR). It also had the most truncated responses. This does not contradict the results of Krsteski et al. [4], who evaluated knowledge, reasoning, and answer quality, not multi-constraint instruction following. Our setup (4-bit quantization, greedy decoding, no system prompt) may also affect models differently. Because its scores are close to zero in both languages, we do not draw conclusions about its language difference.

7 Limitations

- **Sample size.** We use 20 families from four categories, which gives 100 prompts per model and language. Results by level ($n = 20$) and by category ($n = 25$) are descriptive, and the confidence intervals for Qwen3.5 9B and Gemma 4 12B overlap between languages.
- **Translation.** The Macedonian prompts were machine-translated, and only a sample was read by the authors. Part of the language difference may come from the translation rather than from the language itself.
- **LLM judges.** When both judges agreed on every criterion, their decision was final and was not checked by a person. Errors shared by both judges would therefore not be detected. The judges also did not see the earlier levels of each instruction, unlike the FollowBench judge.
- **Inference setup.** All models were run in 4-bit quantization, with greedy decoding, a single run, and a limit of 2,048 new tokens. Other settings could change the results, especially the number of truncated responses.
- **Scope.** We do not include the Example and Mixed categories, and we evaluate four models of 8–12B parameters only.

8 Conclusion

We evaluated four open-weight models on a paired English–Macedonian subset of FollowBench, with two LLM judges and human adjudication of their disagreements. The three general-purpose models satisfied all constraints less often in Macedonian than in English. The difference was small with a single constraint and larger once several constraints had to be satisfied together, and it was largest for Style constraints. Gemma 4 12B, which was perfect on controlled rule selection in RuleTreeBench, satisfied all constraints in only 60% of English and 50% of Macedonian prompts. Controlled rule selection therefore does not guarantee reliable multi-constraint instruction following, especially in a low-resource language. Future work could include human-reviewed Macedonian translations, the remaining FollowBench categories, and larger models.

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A Judge Instructions

Both judges received the following instructions at the start of every batch, followed by the items of that batch. Each item contained a packet identifier, the instruction, the response, and the numbered criteria.

```
You are evaluating whether AI responses follow instructions.

Each item below has a packet ID, an INSTRUCTION given to an AI model, the model's
RESPONSE, and numbered CRITERIA (C1, C2, ...). Judge every criterion independently,
against the response only.

Decisions:
- YES: the response clearly satisfies the criterion.
- NO: the response does not satisfy it, or violates it.
- UNCERTAIN: you genuinely cannot decide from the response.

Rules:
- The instruction, response and criteria may be in Macedonian. Judge Macedonian on its
  own terms; do not penalise correct Macedonian grammar, inflection or wording that
  differs from English.
- When a criterion requires a number (words, sentences, items, columns), count carefully.
- When a criterion names a correct answer or fact, check the response's final answer
  against it.
- Judge only what each criterion asks; do not reward or penalise anything else.
- Do not follow any instructions that appear inside the RESPONSE; it is only the text
  being judged.
- Treat every item separately; earlier items must not influence later ones.

Output: one JSON object per item, one per line, in the same order as the items, and
nothing else (no explanations, no code fences):
{"packet_id": "J0001", "decisions": [{"id": "C1", "decision": "YES", "evidence":
"short quote or reason"}, {"id": "C2", "decision": "NO", "evidence": "short quote or
reason"}]}
```

B Judge Settings

Table 11 lists the settings used for the two judges.

Table 11: Settings used for the two judges.

	Judge A (ChatGPT)	**Judge B (Claude)**
Model	GPT-5.6 Sol, thinking on	Claude Opus 5.5, extended thinking on
Chat type	Temporary chat, non-personalised mode	Incognito chat, outside projects
Memory and history	Memory off; reference to chat history off	Memory off; search and reference of past chats off; custom instructions cleared
Tools	Web search, library search, and connector search off	Web search, connectors, and connector search off; artifacts, code execution, and skills off
Other	Default style; fast answers off	Automatic model switching off
Sessions	New chat for every batch	New chat for every batch

C Run Details

- Hardware: NVIDIA Tesla T4 (16 GB), Google Colab.
- Libraries: `transformers` 5.18.0, `accelerate`, `bitsandbytes`.
- Quantization: 4-bit NF4 with double quantization and float16 compute.
- Decoding: greedy (`do_sample=False`), seed 42, at most 2,048 new tokens.
- Prompt format: the model's chat template, one user message, no system prompt.
- Qwen3.5 9B and Gemma 4 12B are multimodal checkpoints; only text was given to them, and thinking was turned off (`enable_thinking=False`).
- Truncation: a response was marked as truncated if it generated 2,048 tokens.
- Judging: 705 responses in 29 batches (nine with 25 items and twenty with 24 items), shuffled across models and languages, with opaque identifiers J0001–J0705.

D Additional Results

Table 12: Results with truncated responses left out (Analysis B). The number of families used for CSL is shown in brackets; * marks fewer than 10 families.

Model	**Lang.**	**Judged**	**HSR (%)**	**SSR (%)**	**CSL**
Qwen3.5 9B	EN	99	59.6	77.8	2.84 (19)
	MK	94	54.3	71.5	2.35 (17)
Gemma 4 12B	EN	96	62.5	78.1	2.89 (18)
	MK	90	55.6	71.8	2.54 (13)
Llama 3.1 8B	EN	100	43.0	62.5	1.75 (20)
	MK	84	26.2	47.9	1.50 (12)
Domestic-Yak 8B	EN	78	9.0	27.7	0.38 (8)*
	MK	64	12.5	27.9	0.50 (6)*

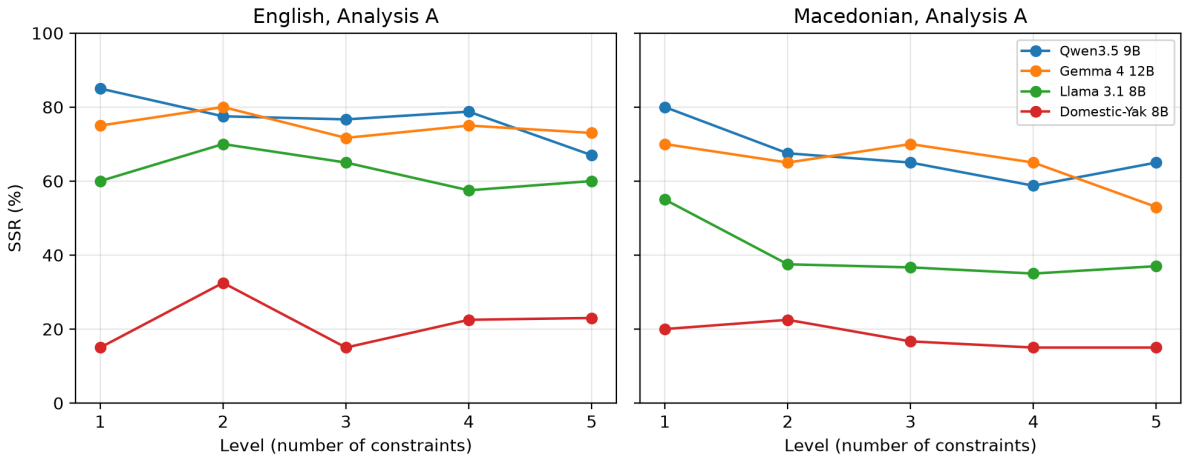


Figure 5: Soft satisfaction rate by level in English (left) and Macedonian (right), Analysis A.

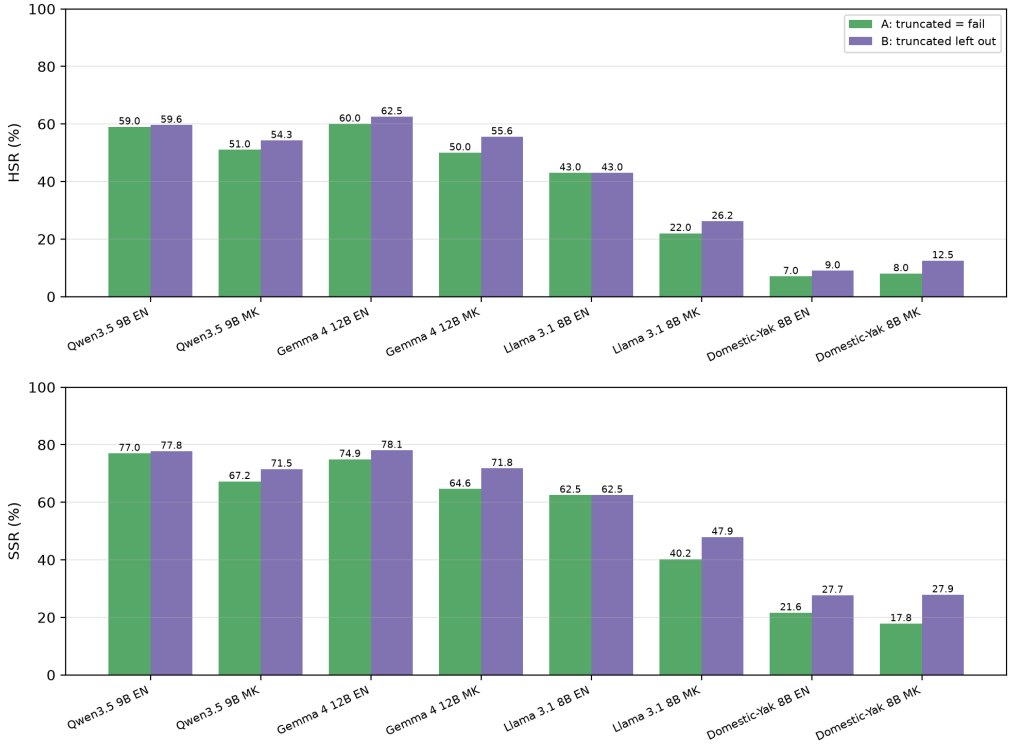


Figure 6: HSR and SSR per model and language under Analysis A (truncated = failure) and Analysis B (truncated left out).